



User Guide

A practical manual for capturing, organizing, finding, automating, and protecting business documents.

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1. Quick start

Upload

Select **Upload documents** or drag files into the browser.

Process

Vaultly extracts text, runs OCR when necessary, and creates a searchable record.

Review

Check the title, date, correspondent, type, tags, and extracted content.

Retrieve

Search for words inside the file or filter by structured metadata.

Recommended first document

1. Upload a non-sensitive sample invoice.
2. Wait until processing finishes.
3. Open it and check the **Content** tab.
4. Add a correspondent, document type, and tag.
5. Search for a unique phrase from the invoice.

Example: Upload "Acme Office Supplies Invoice 1048.pdf." Set Correspondent to "Acme Office Supplies," Type to "Invoice," and Tag to "Accounts Payable." Searching for "1048" should return it.

2. Dashboard

The Dashboard is the starting point after sign-in. It summarizes the collection and provides quick access to uploads and saved information.

Feature	What it does	Example
Search bar	Searches titles, extracted text, and indexed metadata.	Enter an invoice number such as <code>VLT-2026-0723</code> .
Upload documents	Adds files to the processing queue.	Upload a PDF invoice or photographed receipt.
Statistics	Shows collection totals such as document and character counts.	Confirm that the total increases after a successful upload.
Saved views/widgets	Provides shortcuts to frequently used filtered collections.	Display "Invoices awaiting payment."

3. Documents

A Vaultly document is more than the original file. It combines the file, searchable content, metadata, permissions, processing history, and optional notes.

Uploading

Use the dashboard upload button or drag and drop. Vaultly accepts common PDFs, images, and office formats supported by the deployment. Multiple files may be uploaded together.

Do not upload password-protected files unless your workflow is prepared to handle them.

Encryption may prevent content extraction.

Document details

Field or tab	Purpose	Example
Title	A clear human-readable name. Vaultly may suggest one automatically.	"July 2026 Internet Invoice"
Archive serial number	An optional unique filing reference.	"FIN-2026-0042"
Date created	The business date of the document, not necessarily the upload date.	The invoice issue date.
Correspondent	The person or organization associated with the document.	"Lanka Telecom"
Document type	The document's category.	Invoice, Contract, Receipt, Tax Record
Storage path	The managed archive naming/location rule.	Finance/2026/Invoices
Tags	Flexible labels for status, topic, department, or retention.	"Paid," "Confidential," "FY2026"
Content	The text extracted from the document and used for search.	Customer names, totals, and invoice references.
Metadata	Technical details such as filename, media type, checksums, and size.	Useful when verifying file integrity.
Notes	User-entered context that should stay with the record.	"Approved by Finance on 25 July."
History	An audit-oriented timeline of changes and processing events.	See when a tag or title was changed.
Permissions	Controls which users or groups may view or change this document.	Restrict payroll records to the HR group.

Editing safely

Select **Save** to remain on the document or **Save & close** to return to the list. Avoid changing metadata merely to test a setting on an important record.

4. OCR and extracted content

OCR converts visible text in scans and photographs into machine-readable content. Documents that already contain embedded text may only need extraction.

What affects OCR quality

- Correct OCR language configuration.
- Straight, well-lit pages with readable contrast.
- Adequate resolution without excessive compression.
- Minimal handwriting, shadows, folds, and background patterns.

Example: A scanned receipt contains "Silver Elephant 926." After processing, that phrase appears under Content and can be found from the global search bar.

When OCR is wrong

Confirm the configured languages, rescan the page more clearly, or correct the indexed Content if your permissions allow it. Keep the original file as the authoritative visual record.

5. Search and filters

Full-text search finds words inside documents. Filters narrow results using structured fields. Combining both is usually the fastest approach.

Method	Use it for	Example
Simple text search	Known names, phrases, or reference numbers.	Silver Elephant 926
Correspondent filter	Everything associated with one organization.	All records from "Acme Supplies."
Document type filter	A business category.	Only Contracts.
Tag filter	Status or cross-category grouping.	Everything tagged "Needs Review."
Date filter	A reporting or retention period.	Invoices created this quarter.
Custom-field filter	Organization-specific structured values.	Cost Centre equals "Sales."

Search tips

- Start with the most distinctive term.
 - Try the exact reference without punctuation if OCR may have split it.
 - Use filters when common words create too many results.
 - Save a useful filtered search as a Saved View.
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6. Organization tools

Correspondents

Represent people or organizations connected to documents. Use one consistent name rather than variants.

Example: Use "ABC Bank" for statements and letters instead of creating "ABC," "ABC Bank Ltd," and "A.B.C. Bank."

Document types

Describe what the record is. Types should be stable business categories such as Invoice, Purchase Order, Contract, Statement, Receipt, Policy, or Employee Record.

Tags

Flexible labels that may overlap categories. Good uses include status, project, department, confidentiality, and retention markers.

Matching

Matching rules help Vaultly suggest or assign metadata from document content. Automatic learning improves as correctly classified examples accumulate. Administrators should review unexpected matches before applying broad automation.

7. Storage paths

A storage path controls how archived files are named and arranged inside Vaultly-managed storage. It may use folders, fixed text, and supported placeholders derived from metadata.

1. Choose a descriptive name.
2. Enter a simple pattern.
3. Use **Preview** with a representative document.
4. Confirm that missing metadata does not create confusing paths.
5. Save and apply it to a small test group first.

Example design: Organize finance documents by year, correspondent, and type so a 2026 Acme invoice has a predictable managed path. Always verify the actual placeholder syntax offered by your Vaultly version using Preview.

Important: Do not manually rename files inside Vaultly's managed media storage. Make changes through the Vaultly interface.

8. Custom fields

Custom fields store information specific to your business that is not covered by standard metadata.

Field idea	Suggested use	Example value
Invoice total	Reporting and approval	LKR 125,000
Cost centre	Department allocation	Operations
Contract expiry	Renewal monitoring	2027-03-31
Approved	Simple workflow status	Yes
Vendor reference	External system lookup	SUP-8842

Choose the correct data type so sorting and filtering behave properly. Avoid duplicating standard fields such as Correspondent or Date.

9. Saved views

A Saved View preserves a useful search/filter arrangement. It provides a repeatable working queue without moving or duplicating documents.

Examples: "Unpaid invoices," "Contracts expiring within 90 days," "HR documents needing review," or "Uploads with no document type."

Give each view a task-focused name. Review shared views periodically so old business rules do not confuse users.

10. Workflows

Workflows automate repeatable actions. They consist of triggers, optional conditions, and actions.

Part	Meaning	Example
Trigger	The event that starts evaluation.	A new document is consumed.
Condition	A rule that must match.	Content contains "INVOICE" and correspondent is Acme.
Action	The change Vaultly makes.	Assign type Invoice, tag Accounts Payable, and storage path Finance.

Safe workflow rollout

1. Write down the intended rule in plain language.
2. Test against a few non-sensitive documents.
3. Check for false matches.
4. Enable the smallest necessary scope.
5. Monitor File Tasks and recently processed documents.

A broad workflow can misclassify many documents quickly. Test conditions carefully before relying on automatic actions.

11. Email intake

Mail accounts and rules let authorized administrators import email attachments into Vaultly.

Typical setup

1. Use a dedicated mailbox such as invoices@company.example.
2. Connect it with the minimum required mailbox access.
3. Create rules for sender, subject, folder, or attachment behavior.

4. Test with one message.
5. Review processed mail and imported documents.

Example: Import PDF attachments from approved suppliers, assign the “Email Intake” tag, and route them to a finance review queue.

Processed-mail history helps explain why a message was imported, skipped, or failed.

12. Downloading, sending, and sharing

Users with permission may download originals or archive versions. Some deployments also support email sending or temporary share links.

- **Original:** the file exactly as uploaded.
- **Archive version:** a normalized or OCR-enhanced version produced during processing, when available.
- **Share link:** access without a normal Vaultly account, usually with an expiration. Treat it as sensitive.

Before sharing, confirm the recipient, document permissions, confidential content, and link expiration. Revoke links that are no longer required.

13. Trash

Deleting a document normally moves it to Trash first. Authorized users may restore it or remove it permanently.

Example: If an invoice is deleted accidentally, open Trash, verify the record, and restore it. Permanent deletion should follow your organization’s retention policy.

14. Personal settings

Settings generally affect the signed-in user rather than the whole deployment. Options may include appearance, language, date display, notifications, list behavior, and update preferences available to that account.

Personal settings are different from **Application Configuration**, which can affect everyone and is restricted to authorized administrators.

15. Users, groups, and permissions

Every person should have an individual account. Groups make permissions consistent for job roles.

Permission	Allows	Example
View	Read or list a resource.	Finance users can view invoices.
Add	Create a resource.	Records staff can create tags.
Change	Edit a resource.	HR managers can update employee record metadata.
Delete	Move to trash or remove, depending on the resource.	Limited to records administrators.

Global and object permissions

Global permissions grant access to a resource type. Object permissions restrict or grant access to particular documents or metadata objects. Ownership may also affect access.

Suggested small-business roles

- **Vaultly Administrator:** deployment configuration, users, diagnostics, and recovery.
- **Records Manager:** metadata design, workflows, and controlled deletion.
- **Department User:** upload, view, and edit permitted department documents.
- **Read-only Auditor:** view approved records without changing them.

Least privilege: do not make routine users administrators. Test a role using a non-admin account before onboarding a team.

16. Application configuration

Configuration options affect the deployment and are intended for trusted administrators.

OCR settings

Control language selection, OCR mode, page rotation, deskewing, image limits, and related processing behavior. Incorrect settings may reduce search quality or increase processing time.

Barcode settings

Enable supported barcode detection and document separation behavior. Test with representative scans before applying it to bulk intake.

Environment-managed settings

Some foundational settings are defined in the VM's private `.env` file and require container recreation. Never place real secrets in Git or screenshots.

Example: Sinhala, Tamil, Chinese, and English OCR require the matching language identifiers and installed language packages. Change languages only after confirming deployment support.

17. File Tasks, Logs, System Status, and Django Admin

Tool	Purpose	When to use it
File Tasks	Shows consumption jobs, status, and failures.	An upload does not appear or OCR fails.
Logs	Displays application events and error details.	An administrator needs technical evidence.
System Status	Summarizes application, storage, database, and service health.	Routine health checks or incident diagnosis.
Vaultly Admin	Low-level administration of database-backed application models.	Only when a documented admin task requires it.

Vaultly Admin is powerful. Changes can bypass normal interface safeguards. Use the standard Vaultly interface whenever possible and take a backup before risky administrative work.

18. Practical business examples

Accounts payable

1. Upload or email the supplier invoice.
2. Verify OCR, supplier, invoice date, and total.
3. Assign Invoice and Accounts Payable metadata.
4. Add an approval status custom field or tag.
5. Use a Saved View for invoices awaiting approval.
6. Mark Paid after settlement while retaining the record.

Contract renewal

1. Upload the signed contract.
2. Assign correspondent and Contract type.
3. Add expiry date and responsible department custom fields.
4. Create a Saved View for upcoming expirations.
5. Use a workflow to tag contracts that match the department's rule.

Employee records

1. Create an HR group with limited permissions.
2. Restrict employee documents to that group.
3. Use consistent document types such as Agreement, Review, and Certificate.
4. Never use broad public share links for sensitive HR material.

Audit request

1. Create a read-only auditor account or group.
 2. Grant access only to the required records.
 3. Create a Saved View for the audit scope.
 4. Remove or expire access after the engagement.
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19. Security, retention, and backups

- Use strong unique passwords and individual accounts.
- Restrict administrator access.
- Review groups and permissions regularly.
- Keep the Ubuntu VM, Docker Engine, and Vaultly image updated through a tested process.
- Protect the VM-only `.env` file and never commit it.
- Define retention and permanent-deletion rules.
- Keep recoverable backups outside the VM.

What to back up

A complete recovery plan needs the PostgreSQL database, document media, application data, export/consume requirements, deployment configuration, and secrets needed to recreate the service.

A VirtualBox snapshot is useful but is not a complete backup strategy. Keep a separate backup on different storage and test restoration.

20. Troubleshooting

Problem	Checks	Next action
Vaultly does not open	Confirm the VM is running, its IP address is current, and containers are healthy.	Administrator runs <code>docker compose ps</code> and reviews logs.
Document not searchable	Wait for processing, inspect Content, confirm OCR language.	Review File Tasks and rescan if quality is poor.
Upload missing	Check supported format, file size, and task status.	Retry once, then capture the relevant error.
Wrong metadata assigned	Check matching rules and workflows.	Correct the record and narrow the automation.
User cannot see a document	Review user, group, global, owner, and object permissions.	Grant only the specific access required.
Guide link fails	Open <code>/static/vaultly-docs/index.html</code> directly.	Confirm the custom image is current and healthy.

Useful VM health commands

`docker compose ps` shows service health. `docker compose logs --tail=100 webserver` shows recent application output. Avoid destructive Docker volume commands during diagnosis.

21. Glossary

Archive version	A normalized or OCR-enhanced derivative retained alongside the original when processing creates one.
Consume	The process of importing and processing a new file.
Correspondent	A person or organization associated with a document.
Metadata	Structured information describing a document.
OCR	Optical Character Recognition: conversion of visible text into searchable text.
Saved View	A reusable saved search/filter arrangement.
Storage path	A managed rule for archive naming and organization.
Workflow	Trigger, conditions, and actions used to automate processing.

22. About and licenses

Vaultly by PBSS is a customized self-hosted document management experience. Its software foundation includes Paperless-ngx and other open-source components distributed under their respective licenses. Source notices and license obligations remain available in the project repository and image.

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